

Because all data in WinFS has relationships, you can theoretically forget about having to synchronise or update information ever

find its way into that. Apparently, once bitten, twice shy: Microsoft isn't making any promises it might not be able to keep for WinFS.

Enough of a history lesson—it's time to understand why we're harping on about WinFS; what radical changes does it promise?

FAT16, FAT32, and NTFS store all your files as a contiguous and continuous stream of bytes. This means an MP3 is stored as a chunk of data on some part of your hard drive. The OS is quite dumb to what that MP3 is, and basically doesn't care. All the OS needs to know is that it should use a media player to open files called "MP3."

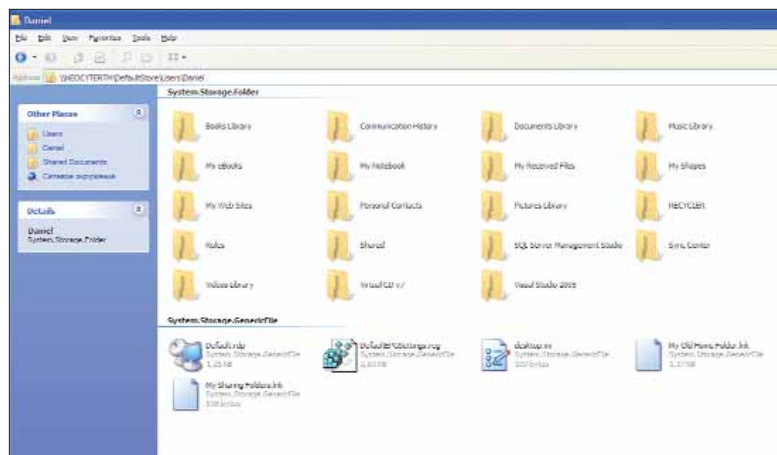
Now WinFS is less of a filesystem, and more of a relationship builder. It still sits on top of an NTFS filesystem, and stores its own data on an NTFS drive, but you cease to see your drive as files and folders. Think of how you get online and find information—you search, right? Why should items on your PC be found in any other manner?

"Now where did I store that PDF?" You remember that it's about your company's finances. Unfortunately, there's also 250 GB of files there that you're not in the mood to sift through. A regular Windows search reveals nothing, or too many PDF files, because the file is named something like 2006-07TR-SD.pdf. You can't even search for text inside the document because it was password-protected. "Was it in a folder or in my e-mail?" You waste precious minutes (even hours) looking for it. Why? Because you cannot search for "A PDF file with transactions that was sent to me between April and June this year by one of my bosses, which I last viewed sometime this month." With WinFS, you will be able to.

Another example is trying to find "contact information of that guy I met on my vacation to Nepal, clicked pictures with, and e-mailed once last year." How can this be made possible?

If only your e-mail client, picture viewer and search utility could talk to each other, they'd collaborate, eliminate false positives from your search—and give you exact results, and fast.

WinFS achieves this by understanding each type of data, each file if you will, generating a report about its contents, the type of file, and all related and relevant information. So when you store a picture, which you receive in your e-mail client from Suresh, with the subject "Pics of our vacation to Nepal," WinFS stores the file in a database as type picture (regardless of JPG, GIF, TIFF, etc.), relates it to your contact Suresh, uses the keywords "Vacation" and "Nepal", and associates it with the date it was received. It can make more associations as well, such as the content of the e-mail, if you set it to do so. Now, when you forward that mail to another friend, say Ramesh, WinFS stores his information as a relationship to that picture. It also does more, like identify a relationship



To end users, Explorer will look very similar, but what appear to be folders are actually database tables that group similar items

between Ramesh and Suresh and keywords such as "vacation", and so on. When you search now, you will find the picture, because WinFS actually had a basic understanding of that file.

The same applies to any file, even files that Windows does not natively recognise. A good example would be a Photoshop PSD file. Let's say you created a PSD file, using the same vacation pictures of Nepal, and added some text layers. Because WinFS requires software vendors to prepare a schema for the way their

“ Hey! Thanks for your Review on Digital Cameras. Before that I was so confused which camera to buy. Thanks to digit after publishing the september 06 issue I continued to buy the Sony Cyber Shot W10 which is indeed rich in performance and it is very sleek and very handy and easy to operate. Thank you Guys.

Pravin (Via Email)

62% DIGIT READERS

BASE THEIR PURCHASE DECISIONS ON OUR REVIEWS

TEST YOUR PRODUCTS WITH US

digit

YOUR TECHNOLOGY NAVIGATOR

Contact: sanket_naik@jasubhai.com